UNICC–NYU Project Guidance

Applied Technical Project (Capstone)

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1. Purpose of This Guidance

This document defines **how you are expected to work, lead, collaborate, and deliver** in the UNICC–NYU Applied Technical Project.

This is not a traditional group assignment.
It is structured to mirror **professional, institutional-grade project execution**, where:

- Work is parallel, not sequential
- Ownership is explicit
- Collaboration is continuous
- Deliverables are real, deployable systems

You are expected to behave as **project leaders**, not task completers.

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2. Program Context

You are participating in a joint **UNICC–NYU collaboration** to build an **AI Safety Lab** suitable for upload into the **AI Sandbox**.

The system you build is treated as a **pre-deployment institutional artifact**, meaning it must be:

- Auditable
- Reproducible
- Understandable by third parties
- Governable with human oversight

This framing drives all expectations below.

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3. Team Structure: The Three-Pillar PM Model

Each team consists of **three students**.
Each student is assigned **one pillar**, and **each pillar is a project**.

You are the **Project Manager (PM)** for your pillar.

Core Principle

You are the PM for your pillar.
The other two students are your *staff* for that pillar.
You are *staff* on the other two pillars.

This is a **matrix model**:

- Clear ownership
- Shared execution
- Continuous collaboration

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4. PM Accountability (Non-Negotiable)

As PM for your pillar, you are accountable for:

- Initiating development independently
- Making and documenting decisions
- Producing working system components
- Managing dependencies and risks
- Integrating your work into the shared system
- Supporting fixes after integration

If something in your pillar fails late in the semester, **ownership remains with you**.

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5. Individual Initiation & Continuous Engagement

Each PM must **initiate development on their own**.

This means:

- You do not wait for the shared repository to be “ready”

- You begin work in your own development context (local, branch, or personal repo)
- You demonstrate early judgment and initiative

All students must work on the project **throughout the entire semester**.

There is no concept of:

- "Waiting for another pillar"
- "Finishing early"
- "Handing off and disengaging"

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6. Collaboration & Integration

Collaboration is **continuous**, not episodic.

Integration points exist to:

- Synchronize assumptions
- Surface conflicts early
- Validate compatibility

Integration is a **merge**, not a handoff.

After integration:

- You remain responsible for your pillar
- You support debugging, testing, and refinement
- Accountability does not dissolve

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7. SMART Objectives (System-Changing Only)

Each pillar has **four distinct SMART objectives**.

These objectives must:

- Produce **tangible system behavior or functionality**
- Be demonstrable in a running system
- Be attributable to one PM

- Exclude generic course deliverables (e.g., literature reviews, risk plans)

Objectives that describe *plans, ideas, or intentions* do not meet the standard.

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8. GitHub Is the Primary Deliverable

Your **primary deliverable is GitHub**.

Written reports and presentations **support** the work but do not replace it.

If something is not:

- In the repository
- Executable
- Reproducible

…it is treated as **not delivered**.

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9. Shared GitHub, Explicit Ownership

Each team maintains **one shared GitHub repository** that is uploadable to the **AI Sandbox**.

Within that repository:

- Pillars must be clearly separated or identifiable
- PM ownership must be explicit
- Git history must show sustained, individual contribution

Individual initiation does not conflict with shared delivery:

- You initiate independently
- You merge into the shared repo
- You remain accountable after merge

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10. AI Sandbox Readiness

All repository contents must be:

- Free of hard-coded credentials

- Independent of personal or proprietary systems
- Runnable by a third party
- Documented clearly

The final demonstration is expected to be:

A clean execution of the shared GitHub repository
inside or compatible with the AI Sandbox.

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11. Weekly Progress Reporting

Weekly updates must be written **as a PM**, not as a group member.

Each update must clearly state:

- What *you* worked on
- What *you* will work on next
- What risks or dependencies you are managing

Team summaries are insufficient.

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12. Final Report: Pillar Learnings & PM Experience

The final report includes a **required individual section** from each PM:

"Pillar Learnings & Project Manager Experience"

This section must document:

- Initial assumptions
- What broke or changed
- Decisions you made or reversed
- How collaboration affected your pillar
- What you would do differently next time

This is a **professional postmortem**, not a personal reflection.

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13. Professional Standards

You are expected to:

- Document decisions and rationale
- Preserve human oversight
- Surface uncertainty and failure cases
- Communicate proactively
- Treat documentation as part of the system

This is **governance-oriented applied work**.
Traceability and clarity are part of the product.

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14. Evaluation

Grades are **individual**, not pooled.

You are evaluated on:

- Continuous engagement
- PM-level ownership
- Quality and rigor of your pillar
- Integration behavior
- GitHub evidence
- Demonstrated learning in the final report

A strong team outcome does **not** compensate for weak PM leadership.

Final Guidance

Approach this project as if:

You will be asked to explain, defend, and hand off your pillar to an institution.

That mindset—not technical sophistication alone—is the standard for this collaboration.

If you are unsure at any point:

- Make assumptions explicit
- Document reasoning
- Raise questions early

This project rewards **judgment, leadership, and learning**, not just output.